TECHNOLOGY ENTREPRENEURSHIP

ENT600

CASE STUDY

COMPANY ANALYSIS

REALME COMPANY

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY



Figure EXECUTIVE SUMMARY.1 realme Logo

The case study looks into realme and its product realme Buds Air 6. This is used by people looking for an affordable option to enjoy wireless listening with noise cancellation. From an entrepreneurial perspective, this product has features that could be considered premium. It offers features including a powerful 50dB of active noise cancellation, LHDC 5.0 audio support, Low Latency Mode (55ms) and is IP55 rated with dust and water resistance. All this can be purchased at an affordable price point.

The information gathered within this research was from secondary sources such as manufacturer details, professional reviews and listings from retailers. The product has three issues which is the bass heavy default sound, voices sounding fake when Transparency mode is active and the call audio sounding less clear during some tests. This is seen as one key issue because it causes the audio to be inconsistent out of the box. Audio is a key factor for why people would purchase earbuds and at the moment the solutions rely on users finding the correct settings with the Realme Link app.

The last three suggestions are to have a default balanced sound with guided tuning, improved voice clarity for transparency calls and a hardware upgrade to two drivers. The suggestion of default balanced sound can be seen as the best recommendation due to the voice tuning option providing an improved first listening experience via firmware upgrade and app. It scored highest in the decision matrix, but the scores are the author’s judgements and not test results.

This solution will involve testing the new sound, developing a prototype, testing with users and ensuring it is user-friendly. This will be recommended if technically possible, acceptable to customers and viable. It will give a clearer and more balanced sound and will improve product differentiation.

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1.0 COMPANY PROFILE

1.1 Company Background



Figure 1.0 COMPANY PROFILE.2: realme headquarters, Shenzhen (realme Community, n.d.)

realme is a consumer electronics brand founded by Sky Li (Li Bingzhong), a former vice president of Oppo, on the 4 th May 2018. It is based in Shenzhen, Guangdong. (Wikipedia, n.d.). Sky Li felt that there was not enough market for consumers aged between 18-25 so wanted to produce affordable and appealing products. (Liao, 2020). This has caused the marketing and design of their products to focus more towards younger people.

The brand has had rapid growth, beginning with a big launch event on a university campus in India. They were able to ship 50 million handsets within nine quarters. (Liao, 2020). They have become one of the fastest growing smartphone brands, selling 100 million units in total by August 2021. This increased to 200 million units in total by November 2023. They now have over 300 million users worldwide in August 2025. (Wikipedia, n.d.). The brand is extremely popular within India, South East Asia and certain parts of Europe. (Storyboard18, 2026). They have their own market page specifically for Malaysia. (realme, n.d.)

On the 7 th January 2026 it was announced that realme would be brought under Oppo as a sub-brand so that they could use their resources. (Business Today, 2026) The brand is run by Sky Li and will be a part of the after-sales service of Oppo. (Michail, 2026) This means they can utilise their resources together which lowers costs. (Storyboard18, 2026) This case study looks into the realme brand, focusing on its youth-orientated sub-brand and looking into their realme Buds Air 6 earbuds.

1.2 Products and Services Offered

realme sells a broad range of consumer devices, with smartphones as its core category and an expanding set of audio and smart accessories. Table 1.1 summarises the main categories listed on the brand's website. The range varies by market.

Table 1.1: Products Offered by realme

Product Category	Examples of Products
Smartphones	GT Series, Number Series, P Series, NARZO Series, C Series
True wireless earbuds	Buds Air series (e.g. Buds Air7, Buds Air8), Buds T series
Neckband earphones	Buds Wireless series
Headphones	Techlife Studio H1
Open-ear audio	Buds Clip
Smartwatches	Watch 5, Watch S5
Tablets	Pad 3, Pad 2
Chargers and cables	SUPERVOOC power adapters and cables
Other accessories	Smart Keyboard, Smart Pen

Source: realme (n.d.). Product names are as listed on the realme India website at the time of writing.

1.2.1 Featured Product: realme Buds Air 6



Figure 1.0 COMPANY PROFILE.3: realme Buds Air 6 (Croma, n.d.)

The realme Buds Air 6 was launched in India in May 2024 (FoneArena, 2024) and in Malaysia in June 2024 at the same time as the Buds Air 6 Pro for the price of RM299 (SoyaCincau, 2024). Later on the official price of the buds was reduced by RM100 to RM199 in Malaysia on the 1 st March 2025 (PriceShop, 2025). A key specification of the buds is shown below in table 1.2.

Table 1.2: Main Specifications of realme Buds Air 6

Feature	Specification	Source
Driver	12.4 mm dynamic bass driver	Croma (n.d.)
Noise cancellation	Up to 50 dB ANC; six microphones for call noise cancellation	Croma (n.d.)
Bluetooth and codecs	Bluetooth 5.3; SBC, AAC and LHDC 5.0	EFTM (2020) *realme Buds Air review*, May. Available at: https://eftm.com/2020/05/realme-buds-air-review-75560 (Accessed: 26 October 2026). FoneArena (2024)
Latency	55 ms low-latency mode	FoneArena (2024)
Protection	IP55 dust and water resistance	Croma (n.d.)
Battery	58 mAh per earbud, 460 mAh case; up to 40 hours with case (ANC off); about 7 hours of music from 10 minutes of charging	FoneArena (2024)
Pairing and app	Google Fast Pair; realme Link app	FoneArena (2024)
Malaysian price	RM199 (from 1 March 2025; previously RM299)	PriceShop (2025)

The realme website now lists newer models, the Buds Air7 and Buds Air8 (realme, n.d.), so the Buds Air 6 is an earlier-generation product. This does not weaken the case study, because the companion app is a general-purpose app shared across realme accessories (Prasad, 2025). Improvements to the app experience would therefore also benefit current and future earbuds.

1.3 Business, Marketing and Operational Strategy

1.3.1 Business Strategy

The brand has built itself on providing affordable products to younger consumers. The Buds Air 6 offers high tech features such as up to 50 dB ANC, LHDC 5.0 and low latency mode (Croma, n.d). At RM199 in Malaysia (PriceShop, 2025) it remains affordable for cost conscious consumers. realme has an ecosystem of IoT devices such as Smart TVs and earphones with

higher markups to compliment their smartphone devices (Liao, 2020). The Buds Air 6 can be seen as a complement to their product range. The Realme Link App can be used with all realme accessories such as smart home devices and fitness bands (Prasad, 2025).

The brand also have a partnership with Oppo meaning they have access to high quality components at low costs (Liao, 2020). Integrating into Oppo in 2026 means they can share resources and services to keep their assets lean whilst still providing competitive products (Business Today, 2026; Michail, 2026). They have partnerships with famous designers such as Naoto Fukasawa to attract younger consumers (Liao, 2020). This helps the founder achieve his goal of having affordable, aesthetically pleasing products (Liao, 2020).

1.3.2 Marketing Strategy

realme has a strong promotion strategy with marketing campaigns at campuses, influencer campaigns and an online community. This helps to create engagement between users and the brand (Liao, 2020). With realme targeting youths, they are focusing on ages 18-25 which aligns with the founder's intention. The company does not spend on flashy outdoor advertising and prefer to spread their marketing through word of mouth (Liao, 2020). Keeping the marketing costs low aligns with their low price strategy.

The product is sold through their official stores on Lazada, Shopee and TikTok in Malaysia. (SoyaCincau, 2024) Additionally it can be bought through realme branded stores and authorised distributors. (PriceShop, 2025). realme Malaysia has also put the Buds Air 6 on sale for RM100 less from 1st March 2025. (PriceShop, 2025) This shows they are actively using price as a marketing strategy to stay competitive.

1.3.3 Operational Strategy

realme obtains components through Oppo's supply chain, which supports lighter assets and lower costs (Liao, 2020). This arrangement is a core part of how the company keeps its prices low. The 2026 integration brings realme into Oppo's after-sales system and aims to improve resource management (Michail, 2026; Storyboard18, 2026). For customers, this may lead to a more consistent service experience.

Firmware updates for realme earphones are delivered through the Realme Link app (realme, n.d.). The update requires the latest app version and sufficient charge in both the earbuds and the case. Both earbuds must also be placed in the open case during the update. realme operates

separate market sites with local currencies, including a Malaysian site (realme, n.d.). This allows prices and product information to be shown for each market.

1.4 Business Performance and Financial Indicators

The realme brand is privately owned, with the sources consulted for this case study providing data on the operation of the brand and Buds Air 6, rather than audited financial information. Table 1.3 shows operational metrics and pricing metrics, these figures should not be interpreted as revenue.

Table 1.3: Business Performance Indicators

Indicator	Figure	Source
Handsets shipped, by late 2020	50 million within nine quarters of launch	Liao (2020)
Cumulative shipments, August 2021	100 million (fastest smartphone brand to reach this)	Wikipedia (n.d.)
Cumulative shipments, November 2023	More than 200 million	Wikipedia (n.d.)
Global users, August 2025	More than 300 million users (not the same as shipments)	Wikipedia (n.d.)
Buds Air 6 Malaysian price	RM299 (June 2024), reduced to RM199 (March 2025)	SoyaCincau (2024); PriceShop (2025)

The shipment milestones show that realme reached a large customer base in a short time, which gives it an audience for software and accessory improvements. At the same time, the 2026 integration into Oppo was described as a move to pool resources and cut costs amid margin pressure (Storyboard18, 2026). Any proposed improvement should therefore be low-cost and software-focused, so that it can reach many users without adding much expense.

2.0 COMPANY ANALYSIS

2.1 SWOT Analyis

A SWOT analysis is used to evaluate the realme Buds Air 6 and the potential development of the proposed improvement to its sound quality and everyday listening experience.

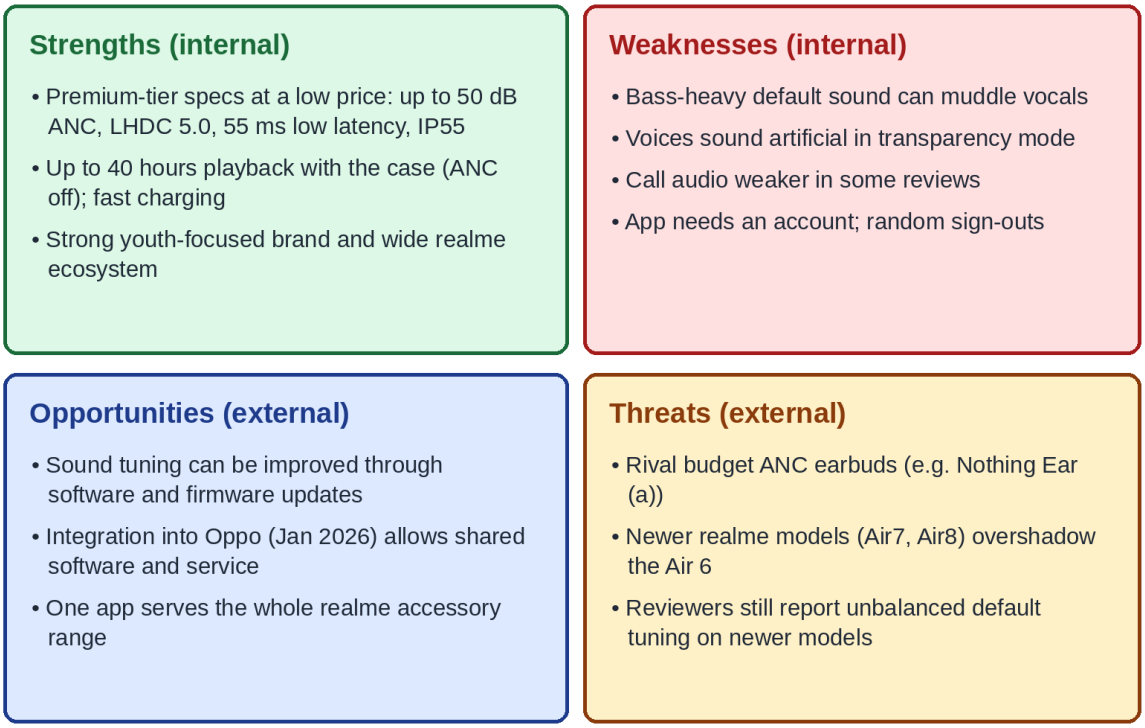


Figure 2.1: SWOT Analysis for realme Buds Air 6

Strengths (Internal Factors)

The Buds Air 6 TWS earbuds provide high-end features including 50dB ANC, LHDC 5.0, 55ms low-latency audio and IP55 water & dust resistance (Croma, n.d). This means users can enjoy reduced background noise from the earbuds, high-quality audio and the earbuds are resistant to water and dust. These earbuds also provide up to 40 hours of playback using the charging case, when the ANC feature is turned off. They also provide a quick charge feature meaning you can charge them for 10 minutes and get around 7 hours of playback (FoneArena, 2024).

Another advantage of these earbuds is the well-known Realme brand within the younger market. They also have a vast range of electronic accessories available (Liao, 2020). The earbuds are affordable and provide modern features which appeals to students and young

professionals looking for good performance at an affordable price. The earbuds also come with the Realme Link app allowing users to manage their compatible devices.

Weaknesses (Internal Factors)

One major downside to the realme Buds Air 6 is that the default setting will be bass heavy which can effect the clarity of voices (Jain, 2024). There is also a lack of flexibility with the sound settings as you will have to use the application to change these manually (Analytics Insight, n.d.). Furthermore, the voices can often feel fake when using the transparency mode and some reviews commented on the poor call quality (Kidwai, 2024). This can effect the user if they are looking for clear voices.

The Realme Link Application is not very user friendly as you will need to set up an account to get the full benefit of the app. Sometimes you will be logged out which can be inconvenient (Kidwai, 2024). Also there is a lack of consistency when it comes to multi device support as there are conflicting statements (Croma, n.d.). Overall realme could improve the reliability of the application and give more clear information about the product.

Opportunities (External Factors)

It can be improved using software and firmware updates to provide better vocal clarity, more balanced sound settings and even better ‘transparent mode’ without having to create a new piece of hardware (realme, no date). By improving the application and listening to customer feedback it can increase customer satisfaction.

As they have merged with Oppo in 2026 this can provide an opportunity to share software development resources and improve customer service (Business Today, 2026) (Michail, 2026). The Realme Link application can be used with multiple compatible accessories meaning the improvements can be implemented across all users (Prasad, 2025). This can provide realme with an opportunity to improve their products whilst still keeping them affordable.

Threats (External Factors)

The realme Buds Air 6 is also subject to competition from other budget-priced wireless earphones, like the Nothing Ear (a) (Kidwai, 2024). If the products are comparable, factors such as sound quality, comfort and usability of the applications can impact consumer choice. This could mean that the Buds Air 6 will struggle to gain popularity due to competitors providing better audio quality at the same price point.

Other threats include new versions of the product coming into the market, such as the realme Buds Air 7 and Buds Air 8 (realme, n.d.) which could take customers away from the Buds Air 6. There have been reports that the Buds Air 8 has unbalanced default audio tuning (Ansari, 2026), meaning audio issues can be present in the product line. If these aren't solved it could cause concern among consumers about the audio quality provided by realme, impacting its reputation in a highly competitive earphone market.

3.0 FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

3.1 Main Problem and Supporting Evidence

This section identifies the main problem using professional reviews of the Buds Air 6 and of closely related realme earbuds that use the same tuning approach. Table 3.1 summarises what the sources report about audio.

3.1.1 Main Problem: Inconsistent Out-of-the-Box Audio Quality

Table 3.1: Evidence on Audio Quality in the Realme Buds Air 6 and Related Models

Source and product	Reported experience	What it shows
Jain (2024), Buds Air 6	The default sound is bass-heavy, and the original mode in the app gives better clarity. Voices sound artificial in transparency mode, and Enhance Voices only helps a little.	Tuning and transparency concerns on the product itself.
Kidwai (2024), Buds Air 6	Sound was described as balanced overall, but voices in transparency mode felt artificial, as if heard through a call.	Sound is good, but transparency voice is a weak point.
Analytics Insight (n.d.), Buds Air 6	Bass-heavy sound with muddled mids and highs, flattened further in Max ANC. Calls had slight distortion and faint voices.	Clarity and call quality concerns.
Pandey (2024), Buds Air 6 Pro	Out of the box the sound is bass-forward, and the bass eats into vocals. An equaliser layer is needed for near-neutral sound.	Same tuning approach on a sister product.
Ansari (2026), Buds Air 8	The default sound is overly boosted and imbalanced. The reviewer changed several settings to get a balanced result.	The tuning issue continues in a newer model.

3.1.1 Bass-Heavy Default Sound

The default sound profile of the Buds Air 6 has been reviewed as having too much bass, along with unclear mid-range and flat treble range due to Max ANC. (Jain, 2024; Analytics Insight, n.d.) This is also true for the Buds Air 6 Pro and Buds Air 8. The bass can overpower the vocal range and the default setting is too boosted overall. (Pandey, 2024; Ansari, 2026) To get a

clearer sound you have to look for the Original Sound Mode or Equaliser within the app. (Jain, 2024) However, Kidwai (2024) found the sound to be balanced.

3.1.2 Artificial Voices in Transparency Mode

Voices also do not sound natural at this point. It sounds like you are listening to someone on the phone (Kidwai, 2024). The Enhance Voices feature is not very helpful at this point (Jain, 2024). Commuters and students will have issues listening to announcements/other people as they can't take their ear buds out.

3.1.3 Weaker Call Audio

Some reviews of the Buds Air 6 have identified that there are some distortions and small voices during calls (Analytics Insight, n.d.). While some sources state that the microphone was good but not as good as the Buds Air 5 (Jain, 2024). This means there is limited evidence to back up this point. Therefore, this is a secondary issue.

3.1.4 Business Interpretation of the Findings

These findings relate to how a product performs and how customers perceive it. Realme may lose out by causing initial disappointment to customers. This can also create more negative feedback about the audio quality of the earbuds in reviews. Furthermore, this could cause problems with standing out from other budget earbuds. However, we do not know how much this will affect them financially. While there are other issues such as the need to have an account and random logging out (Kidwai, 2024), these are not crucial issues. Therefore, realme must ensure their default tuning aligns with what their target customers would expect from the audio quality.

3.2 MAJOR PROBLEM SUMMARY

A key issue is the bass-heavy default sound on the Buds Air 6, making vocals sound muffled. This has been reported in several reviews of the Buds Air 6, and others within the range (Jain, 2024; Analytics Insight, n.d.; Pandey, 2024; Ansari, 2026). This will affect a user's initial experience when using the earbuds, therefore is a key factor in purchasing earbuds. Having robotic voices in transparent mode and lower quality voice calls will be secondary reasons as they were reported less.

The goal is to have clear, balanced audio that is easily accessible without having to change settings in the app. It also aims to keep the hardware of the earbuds the same, keeping ANC and battery life the same.

3.3 ALTERNATIVE SOLUTIONS

3.3.1 Balanced Default Sound Profile

A firmware update would be implemented to create a balanced sound profile, such as the original sound option which is the default setting. Those who like a heavy bass output would still be able to use the profile with heavy bass. This would help those who needed to change the sound options manually to get a clearer sound (Jain, 2024; Ansari, 2026).

The benefits of this are that it would solve the issue automatically for all users, is a software solution and would have minimal cost. The drawbacks are that some people purchase the headphones because they like a heavy bass output, whilst the sound was balanced overall (Kidwai, 2024). realme would also need to do testing to ensure that the change has been implemented on all versions of the earbuds and app. They rarely provide updates for their earbuds (Jain, 2024).

3.3.2 Guided Sound Setup at First Connection

This solution keeps the existing default setting, however gives the user a brief tutorial option to choose between a balanced and bass sound when connecting the earbuds for the first time. It will save this to the earbuds. This solves the issue of users not being able to get the clear sound by searching for the original sound mode/ equaliser option (Jain, 2024; Pandey, 2024).

The benefits of this is that it allows users to personalise their listening experience and easily access the best setting. However, it doesn’t help users unless they download the app. The app requires an account to use (Kidwai, 2024) therefore some people won’t even see this option. It also adds more steps to the initial process.

3.3.3 Dual-Driver Hardware Upgrade

This would upgrade the Buds Air 6 to a dual driver system, like the Pro model. It would have two drivers, one 11mm bass driver, and one 6mm tweeter (Pandey, 2024). This would allow vocals to be clearer due to a separate driver for the higher frequencies. This would be a new model.

The benefit of this would be that it has the most potential to improve the audio quality. However, there are several issues with this idea. Firstly, it requires new hardware making it more expensive and a longer development time. Secondly, it wouldn't help current owners. Thirdly, it is overlapping with the Pro model. The pro still requires an equaliser to provide close to neutral sound (Pandey, 2024). So it may not be possible to solve the issue by just adding hardware.

3.4 Comparison and Evaluations

Table 3.2 compares the three solutions on the same five points, using plain ratings instead of scores.

Table 3.2: Preliminary Weighted Decision Matrix

Point of comparison	Balanced default sound profile	Guided sound setup	Dual-driver upgrade
Improves audio clarity	Good	Good	Best
Easy for users to find the better sound	Very easy, it is automatic	Medium, needs the app	Easy, built into the hardware
Cost	Low	Low to medium	High
Development effort	Low, firmware only	Medium, firmware and app	High, new hardware
Main drawback	Bass lovers may be disappointed	Only helps users who install the app	New model, does not help existing owners
Overall	Recommended	Second choice	Option for the future

Explanation of the scores

The balanced default audio setting provides an automatic solution to the issue which is a low cost software change. However, customers who enjoy high bass may be disappointed by this option (Kidwai, 2024).

The guided audio option allows the customer to choose their preferred audio. However, this will only benefit those who have downloaded the app and you will need to sign up for an account. The dual driver upgrade provides the clearest audio. This can be shown from the example of the Buds Air 6 Pro which has both a bass driver and tweeter (Pandey, 2024). However, this requires new hardware and this will be the most expensive option. These scores

are based on the evidence provided in table 3.1 and the solutions provided within section 3.3. These are not the results of testing but should be verified using listening tests and a cost analysis.

4.0 CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATION

4.1 Summary of Findings

The main issue with these headphones is the bassy default sound. Many reviewers mentioned that the voice on these headphones can be muffled and requires users to locate the original sound mode in the app (Jain, 2024). Other issues include robotic voices when in the transparency mode and low quality sound for calls. These issues aren't reported by many sources but there isn't any evidence to suggest everyone who owns these headphones will have these issues. Overall they have a good balance of sound (Kidwai, 2024).

4.2 Recommended Solution and Justifications

The balanced default audio profile would be the best solution to use. This was given the highest score in the comparison (Table 3.2). Because it solves the problem without user effort, does not need any new hardware and would be an inexpensive solution to the issue. The guided audio settings would be the second choice, whilst the dual driver upgrade would be the future choice due to the high cost.

A firmware update would be used to create a balanced audio profile. This could be similar to the original audio mode. If someone wants a heavy bass then they can still select this profile. There would be no change to the hardware, ANC performance or battery life. This would be done by realme as the firmware is proprietary.

4.3 Implementations Overview

4.3.1 Implementation

This recommendation should be implemented using a formal product development process. First, realme needs to understand how the current default sound performs before it develops a new profile. The new profile should only be released once testing shows that the sound is clearer, that listeners prefer it, and that ANC and battery life have not been affected.

Table 4.1 summarises the plan.

Phase	Proposed Activity	Expected Outcome
Baseline Analysis	Baseline Analysis	Baseline Analysis
Measure current sound modes	Measure current sound modes	Measure current sound modes
Identify sound issues	Identify sound issues	Identify sound issues
Tuning Development	Tuning Development	Tuning Development
Improve vocals and balance bass	Improve vocals and balance bass	Improve vocals and balance bass

The release in phase 5 can use the existing update route, since realme delivers earphone firmware updates through the Realme Link app and the update needs the latest app version and enough charge in both earbuds and the case (realme, n.d.).

4.3.2 Expected Impacts

Users will enjoy improved audio from first use and could receive less negative feedback about the audio. This can also improve perceived value for budget focused customers. These are all predicted benefits however will only be known once technical and listening tests have been performed. realme would also need to ensure that customers looking for powerful bass do not feel disappointed by a more balanced default setting.

4.4 Financial Considerations

From a financial perspective, realme should consider the cost of tuning, testing and releasing the firmware, together with customer support, compared with the benefit of fewer returns and more positive reviews. No information on realme’s costs or sales of the Buds Air 6 was found, so this cannot be estimated here. Because the change is software only, the cost should be much lower than a hardware redesign. The tuning could also be reused across other earbuds, since realme is now part of Oppo (Business Today, 2026) and uses one app for its accessories (Prasad, 2025).

5.0 CONCLUSION

The case study concluded that the key issue with the realme Buds Air 6 is that the default audio is bass heavy. This impacts the clarity of vocals and users will need to find the original audio profile or the equaliser within the app to get improved audio quality. Reviews mention that the audio sounds very artificial when using transparency mode and the audio within calls was less clear. However, these issues were not mentioned as often, so will be seen as secondary issues. There was some conflicting evidence as the audio was found to be balanced overall (Kidwai, 2024). It also does not give information on how many owners are impacted.

The solutions that were discussed were; balanced default audio profile, interactive audio set up and improved hardware using a dual driver. The balanced default audio profile received the highest score in the decision matrix (4.30/5). The interactive audio set up was next with a score of 3.60 and then the improved hardware with a score of 3.45. This was the best solution as it will improve audio for all users, no extra hardware is needed and it is not a costly solution. The improved hardware will give the best audio but is quite costly and take time to develop. Therefore, it would be best to implement the balanced default audio.

These scores are subjective and will need to be tested. The new default audio profile will need to be tested to improve audio quality, ANC, battery life and stable connectivity. It will also need to be validated by listeners and those who like bassy audio. Financially it will also need to be analysed before being released. Overall the case has shown that a change in the default settings can be done through software to meet customer requirements and improve their competitive advantage.

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